The Backup Care Conversation

How to ask the family who could step in for the people who help your mother.

Your sister has never missed a Tuesday, so nobody has ever needed to ask who else could drive. The neighbor looks in most mornings, and it has never come up who would if the neighbor were away.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: hear from each person what they do now and what they might be willing to do. It isn't for handing out jobs or changing the routine.

Who should be there

Your mother, first. It's her week being talked about, and AARP's planning guide for families says a plan should never be made without the participation, knowledge and consent of the person it's for. [1]

Then the people who help now, and the relatives who might. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who helps now or will be helping, and AARP's guide points out that someone doesn't have to live nearby or have large blocks of time to be of value. The neighbor may prefer a short chat of their own, and that's fine. [2] [1]

Tell your sister beforehand what the conversation is about, so it doesn't land as a review of her Tuesdays. Ask someone other than the person leading to keep the notes.

How to open

Nothing has happened, so say that first. Then say what you'd like to do, and what you're not doing.

- “Nothing's wrong. Things are going well, which makes this an easy time to talk about it.”
- “We've never written down who does what. I'd like us to do that, and to ask who could fill in if one of us were away for a week.”
- “Nobody is being signed up for anything today. ‘Maybe’ and ‘I'd rather not’ are both fine answers.”

Questions to ask

Ask your mother

1. Here is the week as we understand it. What have we missed?

2. If one of us couldn't come for a week or two, who would you be comfortable having instead?

Ask the people who help now

1. What do you do in an ordinary week, and how is it going on your end?

2. Is anything coming up for you that might change your days?

3. When you've had to miss a day, what happened?

Ask everyone

1. What would you be willing to do if you were asked, and what wouldn't you?

2. Is there someone outside the family, a friend or another neighbor, who might be glad to be asked?

3. What have you noticed that you'd like a professional to hear about?

How to write down what was said

Write each answer the way the person gave it. “Maybe” and “I'd need to check” are answers; don't round them up to a yes. Where two people remember the routine differently, write both.

PART OF THE WEEK	WHO DOES IT NOW	WHO SAID THEY MIGHT COVER	IN THEIR WORDS
Tuesday drive	My sister	My brother, maybe	“I could do a Tuesday if I know a couple of weeks ahead.”
Morning look-in	The neighbor	Nobody yet	Nobody in the family has asked anyone.

What not to decide yet

Some of these take a professional who meets your mother, and the notes from today are what you'd bring. The others don't need settling at all. Leave them open.

- Whether the help your mother has now is enough.
- Whether any part of her week should change.
- Who ought to be doing more.

- Anything about her home or her medications.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone, your mother included.
- Who will take each concern to her doctor, her pharmacist or your care consultant.
- What would bring you back to this page: a date, or a change in someone's work, home or health.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a disagreement, sign anyone up or tell you what a professional will say. It gets each person's own answer onto one page, the maybes included.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has talked about who might cover for whom, and each person's answer is on paper in their own words. The care interview places those answers in the fuller picture of your mother's situation, going area by area, and turns them into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting